

A Giant Tortoise Took a Walk and a Whole Neighborhood Helped

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Picture this: you're eating dinner and look out the window. A giant tortoise is walking down your sidewalk! That's what happened to 5-year-old Sara Westfall in Scottsdale, Arizona. She spotted a huge **sulcata tortoise** named Rex **moseying** down the street. Rex looked like a dinosaur. He was a couple of feet long and could weigh up to 200 pounds. The neighbors were amazed. Where did he come from? Was he okay? Everyone wanted to help. **Sulcata tortoises** start out tiny the size of a golf ball. They are so cute that people buy them without knowing how big they get. But they grow into the **third-largest** tortoise in the world! They can live **150 years**, dig huge holes, and knock over furniture. Many owners can't handle them, and **rescues** are full. In Arizona, one **rescue** takes in about 1,250 sulcatas a year. But Rex was lucky. His neighborhood came together. They knocked on doors, asked around, and finally found his owner. Rex's adventure shows that owning a giant tortoise is a big responsibility. As one expert said, "If you do your homework, they can be a fantastic pet. You just have to be **prepared**."

Word Treasure

sulcata tortoise -- a species of large African tortoise that can grow very big

moseying -- walking in a slow, relaxed way without hurry

rescue -- a place that takes in abandoned or unwanted animals and finds them new homes

third-largest -- the third biggest in a group; here, the sulcata is the third-largest tortoise species in the world

150 years -- the expected lifespan of a sulcata tortoise; much longer than most pets

prepared -- ready and knowing what to do; the expert said you must be prepared to own a giant tortoise

Background you need

The sulcata tortoise (a giant African species) is popular as a pet but can grow to 200 pounds and live 150 years. In Arizona, the climate is warm like their native desert, so many people keep them, but rescues are overwhelmed with abandoned tortoises. This story is a reminder that unusual pets require long-term commitment.

Break it down

WHO: A giant sulcata tortoise named Rex and a 5-year-old girl named Sara Westfall.

WHAT: Rex went for an unexpected walk in a Scottsdale, Arizona neighborhood, surprising everyone.

WHERE: Scottsdale, Arizona.

WHY: The tortoise escaped and the neighborhood came together to find his owner, showing that owning such a pet requires responsibility.

Why it matters

This story reminds us that pets, even unusual ones, need lifelong care, and that communities can work together to help lost animals find their way home.

Test what you remember

1. What is the name of the tortoise in the story?

- ☐ (A) Sara
- ☐ (B) Rex
- ☐ (C) Scottsdale
- ☐ (D) Sully

2. Where did this happen?

- ☐ (A) Florida
- ☐ (B) Arizona
- ☐ (C) Virginia
- ☐ (D) California

3. How heavy can a sulcata tortoise become?

- ☐ (A) Up to 20 pounds
- ☐ (B) Up to 100 pounds
- ☐ (C) Up to 200 pounds
- ☐ (D) Up to 500 pounds

4. What do sulcata tortoises start out as?

- ☐ (A) The size of a golf ball
- ☐ (B) The size of a soccer ball
- ☐ (C) The size of a car
- ☐ (D) The size of a dinner plate

5. How long can a sulcata live?

- ☐ (A) 15 years
- ☐ (B) 50 years
- ☐ (C) 100 years
- ☐ (D) 150 years

6. What did the neighborhood do to help Rex?

- ☐ (A) Called the police
- ☐ (B) Knocked on doors to find his owner
- ☐ (C) Built a fence
- ☐ (D) Gave him away

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: C 4: A 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. **Rex's owner (positive):** They were probably grateful the neighborhood helped find him and learned that their pet can be a handful.
2. **Neighbors' perspective:** They were amazed and willing to help, showing kindness and cooperation.
3. **Animal rescue experts:** They might say this is a common problem, as many people buy sulcatas without understanding how big and long-lived they become, and that rescues are already full.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):